

Kiran Modi

✉ kiran.modi@unt.edu

☎ 224-410-2188

G. Brint Ryan College of Business
University of North Texas
1307 W Highland St. Denton, TX, 76201

Citizenship & Visa Status

Citizenship	Indian
Visa Status	Authorized to work in the U.S. without sponsorship from employer/H-4 EAD

Education

2021-2026	Ph.D., Finance, University of North Texas
2020-2021	M.S., Finance, University of North Texas
2008-2011	Chartered Accountant (CA), Institute of Chartered Accountants of India (ICAI)
2005-2008	B.Sc. Business, Gujarat University, India

Awards & Honors

2026	Doctoral Directors Choice Award, FIREL, UNT
2024-2025	Outstanding Student Award, The Ascend Gala, UNT
2023	Best Summer Research Paper Award, FIREL Department, UNT
2022	Best Summer Research Paper Award, FIREL Department, UNT
2021-2025	Tuition Benefit Program Award, UNT
2020-2021	Outstanding Student Award, The Ascend Gala, UNT

Job Market Paper

ESG Ratings, Ownership Structure, and Firm Value

I examine how MSCI Environmental, Social, and Governance (ESG) rating changes affect institutional ownership and stock returns in U.S. firms from 2013 to 2023. I focus on three observable ownership shocks: ESG rating upgrades and downgrades, rating changes crossing MSCI's BB threshold for ESG-index inclusion, and firms added to or removed from ESG-focused exchange-traded funds (ETFs). For identification, I use two-way fixed effects, propensity-score matching, difference-in-differences, and MSCI's 2012Q4 mass coverage initiation of 1,602 firms as a quasi-natural experiment. Using these methods and event-study tests, I find that ESG upgrades are associated with a modest 0.203% increase in institutional ownership in the baseline model, while the evidence for downgrades is stronger in matched and DiD specifications. BB downgrades and ESG ETF removals show the clearest negative ownership patterns, with ETF removals associated with a 1.361% decline in 13F holdings. Stock-price reactions to rating changes are generally small

and sensitive to the abnormal-return model, although downgrades followed by ETF removals are associated with negative abnormal returns. Coverage initiation is followed by a 1.16% increase in institutional ownership, consistent with an ESG visibility channel. Overall, the results suggest that ESG ratings are associated with institutional ownership changes primarily through visibility, screening, and exclusion-related channels, rather than through broad immediate valuation effects.

Working Papers

ESG ratings, ownership and stock returns- Cross country analysis

This paper examines the relation between MSCI ESG rating changes, ESG-focused ownership, and stock returns globally. Using MSCI ESG rating changes and the holdings data of 2,585 ESG-focused open-end equity funds from Morningstar Direct, this paper finds that ESG-fund ownership is higher among better-rated firms, rising from 0.13% of shares outstanding for CCC-rated firms to 0.83% for AAA-rated firms, and firms above the BB index-eligibility cutoff are held more heavily than firms at or below BB. However, rating changes are not associated with the expected short-run increase in aggregate ownership percentage: upgrades show a small negative ownership coefficient, while downgrades are not statistically significant. A propensity-score-matched difference-in-differences analysis provides similar evidence, showing no robust ownership-percentage association around rating events within the six-month event window. The evidence is stronger at the fund-participation margin, where downgrades are associated with 0.1349 fewer ESG-focused fund holders per firm-month and BB downgrades with 0.2316 fewer fund holders. Stock-return evidence is small on average but more visible around the BB threshold: U.S. BB upgrades are associated with positive abnormal returns of roughly 0.2% to 0.6%, while BB downgrades in Australia and Switzerland are associated with negative abnormal returns of roughly 0.7% to 1.5%. Overall, ESG rating changes are most informative around the BB index-eligibility threshold, and fund participation captures investor response better than aggregate ownership.

Work in Progress

- Governance by Contract: Shareholder Agreements and Corporate Control
- Activism by blockholders (with Stuart Gillan, Daniel Rettl & Vivek Acharya)

Teaching

University of North Texas

2026 - Present	Lecturer	Introduction to Finance (FINA 3770) Financial Markets and Institutions (FINA 4400)
2023-2026	Instructor	Introduction to Finance (FINA 3770) - 4 courses Financial Statement Analysis and Liquidity Management (FINA 4300)
2021-2024	Teaching Assistant	Introduction to Finance (FINA 3770) Introduction to Derivatives (FINA 4210) Financial Statement Analysis and Liquidity Management (FINA 4300) Financial Management (FINA 5170)

Research Focus

ESG/sustainable investing, ownership structure, corporate governance, activism

Research Skills

- **Econometrics & Data Analysis:** Stata, SAS, R (tidyverse, data.table, ggplot2), Python (pandas, NumPy, statsmodels, scikit-learn)
- **Data Management & Research Workflow:** Git/GitHub, Jupyter Notebooks, Excel macros for automated data download (Morningstar Direct), WRDS, Bloomberg Terminal, MSCI, CRSP/COMP, S&P Capital IQ
- **Visualization, Reporting & Document Preparation:** Excel (advanced, VBA), Tableau, LaTeX, Overleaf, Beamer
- **Natural Language Processing / LLM Applications:** Python pipelines for SEC EDGAR scraping; contract-clause extraction using OpenAI GPT-4o for large-scale shareholder agreement analysis

Other Experience

2026 - Present	Lecturer: Finance, Insurance, Real Estate & Law, UNT
2021-2026	Research Assistant, UNT
2026	SWFA Paper Discussant
2024	FMA Paper Discussant
2011-2017	Principal Chartered Accountant Financial Analyst / Consultant Darshan A Shah & Co - Chartered Accountant, India
2008-2011	Intern Financial Statement Auditing & Taxation Aniket B Shah & Co. - Chartered Accountant, India

References

Dr. Stuart Gillan

Professor, G. Brint Ryan Finance Chair
G. Brint Ryan College of Business
University of North Texas
Stuart.Gillan@unt.edu

Dr. Meredith Rhodes

Assistant Professor
G. Brint Ryan College of Business
University of North Texas
Meredith.Rhodes@unt.edu

Dr. Takeshi Nishikawa

Associate Professor
G. Brint Ryan College of Business
University of North Texas
Takeshi.Nishikawa@unt.edu

Dr. Xun Bian

Associate Professor
G. Brint Ryan College of Business
University of North Texas
Xun.Bian@unt.edu

